Sweet Ruin and Safeway

By Tony Hoagland

INTRODUCTION

You probably already know more about parents than you'd like to. When they were kids, they walked through three-foot snow drifts to school and home again, uphill both ways. They never had an allowance, or asked for one. They always did their homework and chores, and they never missed a church meeting.

And now they work their fingers to the bone so you can enjoy all the luxuries they had to do without. And are you grateful? Do you understand them?

Maybe.

Sometimes.

You try, anyway. . . . Sweet Ruin by Tony Hoagland

Sweet Ruin

Maybe that is what he was after,
my father, when he arranged, ten years ago,
to be discovered in a mobile home
with a woman named Roxanne, an attractive,

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recently divorced masseuse.

He sat there, he said later, in the middle
of a red, imitation-leather sofa,
with his shoes off and a whiskey in his hand,
filling up with a joyful kind of dread--
like a swamp, filling up with night,

--while my mother hammered on the trailer door
with a muddy, pried-up stone,
then smashed the headlights of his car,
drove home,
and locked herself inside.

He paid the piper, was how he put it,
because he wanted to live,
and at the time knew no other way
than to behave like some blind and willful beast,
--to make a huge mistake, like a giant leap

into space, as if following

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a music that required dissonance
and a plunge into the dark.
That is what he tried to tell me,
the afternoon we talked,
as he reclined in his black chair,
divorced from the people in his story
by ten years and a heavy cloud of smoke.
Trying to explain how a man could come
to a place where he has nothing else to gain

unless he loses everything. So he
louses up his work, his love, his own heart.
He hails disaster like a cab. And years later,
when the storm has descended
and rubbed his face in the mud of himself,

he stands again and looks around,
strangely thankful just to be alive,
oddly jubilant--as if he had been granted
the answer to his riddle,
or as if the question

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had been taken back. Perhaps
a wind is freshening the grass,
and he can see now, as for the first time,
the softness of the air between the blades. The
    pleasure
built into a single bending leaf.

Maybe then he calls it, in a low voice
and only to himself, *Sweet Ruin.*
And maybe only because I am his son,
I can hear just what he means. How
even at this moment, even when the world

seems so perfectly arranged, I feel
a force prepared to take it back.
Like a smudge on the horizon. Like a black spot
on the heart. How one day soon,
I might take this nervous paradise,

bone and muscle of this extraordinary life,
and with one deliberate gesture,

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like a man stepping on a stick,

break it into halves. But less gracefully

than that. I think there must be something wrong

with me, or wrong with strength, that I would

break my happiness apart

simply for the pleasure of the sound.

The sound the pieces make. What is wrong

with peace? I couldn't say.

But, sweet ruin, I can hear you.

There is always the desire.

Always the cloud, suddenly present

and willing to oblige.

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AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

TRANSITION

I wish I could never see it, I wish I could never see my parents for anything other than the all-knowing beings who brought me into this world but ignoring their flaws gets harder and harder as I age. It doesn't make me love them any less. It just makes me think. Finding out that your parents are people too with their own unique set of failures and shortcomings is sort of like finding out Santa Claus isn't real. I never wanted to know. I wish they could've just kept feeding me the lies so I'd feel safe and didn't have to cope with their loss . . . . Safeway by Tony Hoagland

Safeway

Even after an hour in her room

with eye shadow and rouge,

moisture whip, lip gloss, and perfume

my mother still looked like she was dying

unexotically,

still looked like a person

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trying to impersonate a person
going somewhere other than the grave,

though she was only going to the store,
after weeks of living
horizontally
while her blood was scoured by detergents
bleached by blasts of subatomic light.

Riding on her bony little head,
the glossy auburn wig
looked like something stolen,
the lame hip pulled her to one side
like the stuck wheel of the shopping cart we pushed

past pyramids of fruit,
down mile long corridors of breakfast food
where cartoon animals shot sugar stars
over an infinity of bowls,

--a landscape which seemed,

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in the brightness and abundance of its goods,
like somebody's idea
of paradise--

and the bright, continual ringing of the registers
was like the sound of happiness
for sale.

I was angry, dutiful, and seventeen,
afraid she was going to read her obituary
in the faces of the shoppers;

frightened they would stop and stare
at the black cloud hovering above our heads
as we moved slow as history
up and down the aisles.

Maybe months of sickness had burned away my mother's
shame
and left in her dry mouth
a taste for irony, maybe she wanted

to show the populace

what death looked like in person
or maybe it was simply her last chance
to make small talk with the neighbors
who stopped to say hello--

Mrs. Johnson, Mrs. Green,
whose kindness I imagined, then despised,
caught awkwardly among them as I was,
between the living and the dead.

But looking back across the years,
the scene looks different to me now. I see
a little group of people, halted
in the midst of life,
their carts jammed up
against the lettuce and the tangerines.

There is no gallows standing there,
no spectral executioner fingering his blade.

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And I seem sweet at seventeen, innocent
even in my rage--
trying to protect
what didn't need protecting
from what couldn't be saved.

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